

Checklist:

New Manager: First Three Months

First, identify your starting path

- Clarify which situation best fits you:
 - ☐ Apprentice: managing part of your existing team
 - ☐ Pioneer: building a new team or function
 - ☐ New Boss: joining an established team as its leader
 - ☐ Successor: taking over for a departing manager

Core checklist for any new manager

- ☐ Accept that the first three months are a ramp-up period
- ☐ Ask lots of questions before trying to prove yourself
- ☐ Learn how the team works before changing too much
- ☐ Build trust through one-on-ones and consistency
- ☐ Define what success looks like for your first 3 and 6 months
- ☐ Notice what is working and what is not
- ☐ Get clear on team goals, values, and norms
- ☐ Be open about your learning curve
- ☐ Resist the urge to act like you already know everything
- ☐ Remember that feeling fully comfortable may take much longer than three months

Relationship checklist

- ☐ Meet key partners and stakeholders early

- ☐ Build one-on-one relationships with each direct report
- ☐ Ask each report how they like to be supported
- ☐ Ask what kind of feedback is most helpful to them
- ☐ Ask how they like to be recognized for great work
- ☐ Ask what worked well with their previous manager
- ☐ Ask what an excellent manager-report relationship would look like to them
- ☐ Invest deliberately in trust, especially if you are new to the team
- ☐ Expect some awkwardness if you are now managing former peers
- ☐ Practice having direct, honest conversations when needed

Learning checklist

- ☐ Learn how decisions get made on the team
- ☐ Learn what “good” looks like in your team’s context
- ☐ Learn the unwritten rules and normal operating patterns
- ☐ Learn current priorities, deadlines, and active projects
- ☐ Learn where the team is strong and where it needs improvement
- ☐ Learn who influences outcomes beyond the org chart
- ☐ Keep a running list of observations, questions, and risks

Team and process checklist

- ☐ Review current team processes and identify friction points
- ☐ Note anything that feels inefficient, unclear, or outdated
- ☐ Decide what should be preserved versus changed
- ☐ Avoid fixing things just to leave a mark
- ☐ Create a short list of the biggest improvement opportunities
- ☐ Align with your manager on ownership and expectations
- ☐ Clarify responsibilities across the team

Personal operating checklist

- ☐ Set aside time each week for reflection

- ☐ Get support from your own manager
- ☐ Find peer managers you can learn from
- ☐ Be careful not to over-index on individual contributor work
- ☐ Shift your time toward coaching, clarity, and team outcomes
- ☐ Accept that your job is now different from your old one
- ☐ Measure yourself by team success, not just personal output

Path-specific checklist

If you are the Apprentice

- ☐ Work with your manager on a joint transition plan
- ☐ Clarify how your scope may evolve over time
- ☐ Understand the people you will be managing
- ☐ Identify team goals and processes that need support
- ☐ Use your context to ramp quickly
- ☐ Watch for awkwardness with former peers
- ☐ Prepare to coach people who used to be your equals
- ☐ Practice difficult conversations early
- ☐ Expect people to share less with you at first
- ☐ Make a plan to reduce IC work before it becomes unsustainable

If you are the Pioneer

- ☐ Write down how you make decisions
- ☐ Define what “good work” means in your function
- ☐ List all responsibilities you used to carry alone
- ☐ Identify what new processes are needed as the team grows
- ☐ Be intentional about team values and culture
- ☐ Decide what qualities you want in new team members
- ☐ Identify which skills your team needs beyond your own
- ☐ Think ahead about how the team should work a year from now
- ☐ Build an external support network if internal support is limited
- ☐ Avoid trying to keep doing all the IC work yourself

If you are the New Boss

- ☐ Use your “new person” window to ask basic questions
- ☐ Meet as many people as possible early on
- ☐ Ask for context before offering strong opinions
- ☐ Treat your fresh start as a chance to reset your identity
- ☐ Give people the benefit of the doubt
- ☐ Ask the reports what support they want from you
- ☐ Listen for what is normal versus what is a real issue
- ☐ Focus your first months on listening, learning, and calibration
- ☐ Invest heavily in building trust
- ☐ Share enough of yourself to make openness possible

If you are the Successor

- ☐ Acknowledge the increased responsibility openly
- ☐ Ask for support from your new manager and peers
- ☐ Tell the team there may be bumps during the transition
- ☐ Avoid trying to be a copy of the previous manager
- ☐ Give yourself permission to lead differently
- ☐ Focus on what the team needs now, not just preserving the past
- ☐ Be honest about your ramp-up while still showing ownership

Simple 30-60-90 focus

First 30 days

- ☐ Listen
- ☐ Learn
- ☐ Meet everyone
- ☐ Understand priorities and norms

Days 31–60

- ☐ Clarify expectations
- ☐ Strengthen relationships

- ☐ Start coaching more actively
- ☐ Identify a few key improvements

Days 61–90

- ☐ Make targeted changes
- ☐ Reinforce team standards
- ☐ Shift fully into manager mode
- ☐ Review progress with your manager and team